EXCERPT | PARENT ROUNDTABLE SERIES

The Why Behind Supplements

How a pharmacist evaluates a foundational supplement for quality, evidence, and safety

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A PHARMACIST'S FRAMEWORK

Five questions I ask before recommending any supplement

1

What is it?

Form and dose

2

Why this child?

Need or deficiency

3

What is the evidence?

For this use

4

Is it quality-made?

Testing and COA

5

Is it safe?

With medicines

> If any answer is unclear, the right recommendation is to wait and find out.

QUALITY IS ON PAPER

Quality you can verify: the label is only the start

Manufacturing standards

Makers must follow current good manufacturing practice rules for identity, purity, strength, and composition.

Certificate of Analysis

A batch-level report confirming identity, potency, and limits for contaminants such as heavy metals and microbes.

Third-party seals

Independent programs such as USP Verified and NSF certification test products against their labels.

> In my product work, I reviewed batch Certificates of Analysis before products reached families.

Dietary Supplement Health and Education Act of 1994; 21 CFR Part 111 (current good manufacturing practice)

INTERACTIONS

Check interactions before adding anything new

Supplement	Interacts with	What to do
Magnesium, zinc	Tetracycline and quinolone antibiotics	Separate doses by several hours; ask the pharmacist for timing
Omega-3 (high dose)	Blood thinners	Ask the prescriber before starting
Vitamin D	Thiazide diuretics	Calcium can rise; monitor as advised
Probiotics	Weakened immune system, central lines	Use only with the care team's approval

> Bring every supplement bottle to medication reviews. Interactions are only caught when the list is complete.

WANT THE FULL DECK?

This is an excerpt from a full parent-education roundtable

- Designed, researched, and presented by a registered pharmacist
- Every clinical claim cited and verified in PubMed
- Written for parents; reviewed to a professional medical-content standard

See the full deck and more

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